



Sandforce 2500

The first OCZ SSDs based on the upcoming enterprise-grade Sandforce 2500 controllers have been spotted.

Agent 001 goes UPS hunting

Blackouts, dirty power and brownouts are becoming a way of life. Agent 001 shows you how to keep your PC protected.

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Prevention is better than cure, as the time-tested adage goes. I'm a firm believer, and with summer around the corner, most of our country will face an increase in power cuts. Now in case you're not among those fortunate ones living in cities such as Mumbai, chances are, your PC will face power outages. I feel a UPS is most needed, even if power cuts are less frequent. Components need constant supply of current, and stable voltages. Fault tolerance levels in terms of volts are very minute, and most power supplies while able to regulate cannot cope with sudden spikes and troughs.

Think of a UPS as a first line of defence. On your checklist should be a UPS with AVR or automatic voltage regulation, otherwise a UPS is little more than a battery backup. You should at least have rudimentary protection from fluctuations to reduce the load on your power supply. Obviously, people with even cheap computers need at least a basic UPS, while if you have blown upward of 50 grand on your machine, you may even want higher-end UPS.

Ratings

VA ratings are not as important, except if you want more back-up time. If you have a basic dual/quad core rig, a rating of 600VA will suffice, as this means the UPS can supply up to (600×0.7) 420 watts. If your machine draws more than 420 watts, the battery will not be able to run your PC in the event of a power cut, and the PC will switch off. For a high-end Core i7, SLI or Crossfire rig, with lots of hard drives, you may need a 1000VA UPS, or even something beefier. Higher VA rating also equates to more backup time on the same configuration, but you end up paying more as well. There's a balance, although, higher VA rating UPS' are arguably better built than the lower models in the same line-up.

Price

Prices for UPSes have fallen, owing to popularity. Big computer markets like Nehru Place and Lamington Road are full of options. Among brands like APC, Numeric, VIP Powersafe, Microtek, V-Guard, I'd give preference to APC and Numeric. In fact, I have used an 800VA Numeric UPS for 6 years now, and just had its battery replaced – the UPS was fine. However, I've recently upgraded my PC, and wanted to run my LCD TV off my UPS too. Shopkeepers are not the most helpful bunch and will try to sell you something cheap. I would give preference to quality over sheer VA ratings, and your PC's life is on the line, so don't play around!

Support

Most brands offer onsite support, and dealers have AMC options, which you should enquire for. I saw a generic 500VA UPS priced at ₹1,300, but steered clear. Next I was shown Microtek, but I didn't like the options available. UPS' are available in different form factors, although if you're keeping yours on the floor, a regular box one will do. From what a couple of vendors told me, and based on feedback from friends, APC is by far the most common, although a lot of pieces are faulty. A good friend who shifted to Delhi recently, bought an APC BR-1500IN and told me he got his replaced four times (within warranty) on account of defective pieces. I recommend the Numeric 500VA for a basic dual core, browsing rig with a 400-watt power supply, and up to 22-inch LCD monitor. This should give you at least 5-10 minutes of backup and comes with a two-year warranty, and is priced at ₹2,100.

Higher-end UPS models not only provide longer backup, but also output more power, and can therefore handle more devices. Additionally, the greater number of relays used means voltage regulation is finer. The 1 KVA model (Numeric SB1000) is also available for those looking for longer backup on beefier systems. This is priced at ₹4,700, while the 1 KVA from APC (BR-1000IN) is priced at ₹5,500. The BR1500 IN from APC commands a price tag of ₹10,500. Numeric's SB1600 is available for ₹8,700 all-inclusive, while the 2KVA model (SB2000) was priced at ₹9,500. Microtek has a 1 KVA model available for ₹3,950.

Decision

Both brands have Pure Sine wave output models as well, although these are priced high enough for me to recommend an online UPS. Numeric's 1 KVA model is called the Digital 1000 LI SW and is priced at ₹9,700. A pure sine wave UPS is nothing more than one that regulates the AC output to resemble a pure sine wave i.e. with minimal steps, whereas regular UPS' output a stepped sine wave. Online UPS' are different beasts, featuring double conversion, where AC current is used to charge the batteries, and

the batteries output is again converted to AC outputted. Such UPS' have the most steady output voltage and isolate your equipment from the mains, but they are prohibitively expensive. Numeric's 1 KVA online model (HP1000 series), retails for ₹15,000, while a set of three batteries would require an additional ₹2,000.

The Numeric SB1600 was not available, and the SB2000 was priced at ₹800 more. In the end, I was able to bring the dealer down by a cool 400 bucks. I paid ₹9,100 for the Numeric SB2000 and that included delivery. My PC, TV, PS3, Blu-Ray player and DAC are just a little safer! 

